Scrolling Past Democracy: Evaluating Existing Solutions

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Introduction

In the previous two memos in the series of “Scrolling Past Democracy,” we have discussed the the modern trends of misinformation spread among youth on social media, as well as taking a look into the possible causes and consequences of this issue through the lens of the Uses and Gratifications Theory of Communication. Ultimately, past research has concluded that not only are social media sites and short form content breeding grounds for misleading information, but also that the further spread of fake news is often fueled through the desire for additional gratification through the form of social utility. While youth strive to derive popularity and connection to peers through the careless spreading of deceiving headlines, the result often ends with youth being more politically divided and polarized than ever due to the rise in online echo chambers. If left unaddressed, these dynamics threaten journalism’s ability to fulfill its democratic functions of informing citizens, fostering public dialogue, and cultivating civic engagement.

Today’s discussion will focus on the solutions to the problem of misinformation spread among youth which are already being implemented in society. This memo will be divided between two current implementations, media literacy education and platform-driven algorithmic interventions, to evaluate how well current efforts address the causes and consequences of youth disengagement as well as open up dialogue to provide additional opportunity space to new solutions. To our possible funders, it is with great hope that today’s discussion will demonstrate both the progress that has been made and the critical gaps that remain, ultimately persuading you of the urgent need to invest in innovative solutions that can truly reconnect youth with credible journalism and democratic engagement.

Existing Solutions

Media Literacy Education

One solution that has been implemented to combat the effects of misinformation spread among youth on social media is media literacy education. Media literacy initiatives aim to equip young people with the tools to critically evaluate information, distinguish credible journalism from not, and to produce and understand media in terms of its social role in democracy (Muringa & Adjin-Tettey, 2024). Media literacy education initiatives are most commonly funded by grants (either private or federal), such as the $30,000 grant awarded to Media Literacy Now Inc. from the Department of State in 2021, but also may be supported by mandated media literacy education programs in K-12 public schools in certain states, including California, Delaware, Illinois, New Jersey, and Texas (USA Spending, 2021) (Media Literacy Now, 2024). This solution mainly combats the consequences of social media misinformation engagement among youth, such as limiting further spread, polarization, and civic disengagement.

One specific example of this solution that has been implemented is Assembly Bill 873, which was signed into effect in 2023 by California Governor Gavin Newsom. This bill establishes mandates which require all public schools in the state of California to implement media literacy into English, math, and history curricula for grades K-12. With this bill, Newsom hopes this new curriculum will aid students in recognizing both reliable news sources and understanding the critical role the media plays in upholding democracy amidst trends of distrust in news outlets among young people (Jones, 2023).

Media literacy education has many benefits in guiding youth towards identifying biases in news content and interacting accordingly. One study by Tufts University found that there is a significant correlation between youth that work to employ media literacy techniques and civic participation. When being asked the question of whether or not they frequently fact-checked

news information they saw on social media, 81% of Americans aged 18-24 who voted answered yes, compared to only 65% of non-voters of the same age group. Similar responses also emerged when asking questions such as “I have compared online content about the same topic across more than one source” and “I take steps to find out who created the content I view online,” with young people who voted answering “yes” to such questions significantly more frequently than non-voters (Siegel-Stechler et. al, 2025). This research ultimately suggests the strengths of media literacy education lie in its ability to foster democratic education by encouraging deliberate news-seeking behaviors and equipping students with the cognitive tools to resist misinformation. Through connecting media comprehension skills to civic outcomes, media literacy initiatives demonstrate their potential to combat disengagement and support more informed democratic participation among youth.

However, media literacy programs are not without limitations. While it addresses the consequences of misinformation (such as civic disengagement) it does little to confront the causes identified in Memo 2, namely the gratification-driven motives behind youth news habits. Memo 2 outlined the existing trends among youth in the sharing of sensational news in hopes of gaining social utility with their peers, rather than the pursuit of news for informational accuracy, often leading to the formation of echo chambers and spread of false headlines. While media literacy programs can help young people simply identify biases and misleading information in content they come across online, it does not address the root cause of their motives when it comes to sharing this information. A study by Cherkas Global University states that youth may even develop parasocial relationships with online political personalities, causing them to repeat information in the hopes of being more like or gaining validation from an influencer, even if they know that the information they are given is false (Kazakov, 2024).

Platform-Driven Algorithmic Interventions

Another strategy being taken to combat the misinformation spread on social media among youth comes from the social media platforms themselves. These interventions involve altering the design of algorithms to limit misinformation spread, flag unverified content, or elevate credible sources. Platforms fund and implement these solutions internally. Unlike media literacy programs, these measures mainly target the causes of the problem, specifically the algorithmic amplification of sensational or misleading content.

One specific example of an algorithmic program is Community Notes on X (formerly known as Birdwatch on Twitter). This program was launched into effect in 2021 and rebranded by Elon Musk after purchasing the app in 2022, allowing users to attach “notes” of context or clarification to content they deem as misleading, which are then voted on as “helpful” or not by a significant number of other users in order to create “a better-formed world” according to Musk (Murphy, 2025).

The strengths of this approach ultimately lie in its public nature and ability to reach millions of youth in an instant. This approach highlights the importance of context and transparency in news media in holding creators accountable for the information they post, as it can be provided by the community even after they post it. This approach is also very strong in terms of meeting youth trends of distrust in traditional news media sources. Trust in official news sources, such as CNN or FOX News, is at an all time low among Gen Z. Thus, youth may be more inclined to trust contextual information provided by fellow citizens, allowing them to still access fact-checking without going through traditional media.

However, platform-driven interventions can also face significant challenges. Although these platforms were designed with the intent to hold creators accountable and ultimately limit the

spread of misinformation, the platform's reliance on users has shown indications toward the opposite effect of actually *encouraging* echo chambers. As social media platforms, namely those as largely used as X, are so vast, it is not possible for all community notes to be approved by professional fact-checkers. Due to this, users have been shown to pressure their own personal community into voting their Community Note into the "Helpful" category, even if it contains misleading information (Kuuse, et. al, 2025). While these programs were created to limit the spread of misinformation in the algorithm, through relying on crowd-sourcing the program ultimately has the potential to put even more misleading information onto the platform than there was to begin with.

Opportunity Space

While both media literacy education platforms and platform-driven algorithmic interventions have worked to take critical steps toward limiting the spread of misinformation among youth on social media platforms, both also exhibit their own fatal flaws. While media literacy programs do well at equipping youth with the necessary tools to identify bias and misinformation in news media, it does little to actually address the unlying reasons for sharing such content. On the flip side, while platform-driven algorithmic interventions succeed in limiting misinformation's spot in the algorithm through providing context and holding creators accountable, it still remains quite vulnerable to echo chambers and misuse of the features due to its reliance on users rather than professionals.

In order to best address the issue of misinformation spread among youth, the opportunity space ultimately lies in analyzing the strengths of both solutions, while also contributing to innovative research into tackling and removing the weaknesses. To break this persistent cycle, it is imperative that we continue to work toward a solution that is able to leverage youth's needs for

social utility gratification while also putting a stop to persistent echo chambers present on social sites that fuel this desire in the first place. We must find a solution that encourages youth to use this need for gratification through finding a solution that rewards the spread of credible journalism and condemns the spread of misinformation.

As funders, you have the potential to aid our team in further contributing to building lasting solutions to the issues of misinformation spread, which has led to increasing civic disengagement among young people. In order to preserve the democratic process in America well into the future, it is with great hope that you have found this Memo informative and feel further invigoration into helping this cause.

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